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Analysis and Classification of Directions in Written Advertisements

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Abstract

In this paper, we analyse directions or *directives*, as labelled by Searle, on a corpus of eighty-four written advertisements published in various magazines and newspapers. Based on our findings, we put forward a typology of directions which consists of four more categories and which we believe may be extremely useful in the production or analysis of the speech acts used in written advertisements. The results of the analysis and the suggested typology can be of interest to both advertisers (senders), in that they may use these specific sub-classes of speech acts to achieve the intended effect on their audience, and to analysts or customers (receivers), who will thus grow more aware of the strategies used by the senders to influence their choices.
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Keywords: advertisement; direction; sender's intention; speech act.

1. Introduction

The rise of capitalism in the 18th century brought about a fierce competition between the organisations that had to fight "for resources, called *capital*, in a free-market environment" (O'Guinn et al, 2012: 55). The successful organisations are able to attract capital in the form of money or other goods by stimulating demand through advertising and other useful tools (O'Guinn et al, 2012: 55). Advertising is, according to The American Marketing Association, any paid form of non-personal presentation and promotion of ideas, goods or services by an identified sponsor, and an advertisement is the result of the action of advertising (Baker, 1994: 369). In other words, advertisements try to induce the feeling that people need a certain product / service or that they should adopt a certain idea.

In order to attain their goals, advertisements focus on certain communication objectives (Clemente, 2002: 26) which also represent the "four basic stages in the purchase decision-making process" (Lamb, Hair, McDaniel, 2012:

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515) of the receiver, namely catching attention, stirring interest, stimulating desire and urging to action. This is called the AIDA model, where A stands for attention, I for interest, D for desire and A for action (Clemente, 2002: 26; Lamb, Hair, McDaniel, 2012: 515). The last stage in the purchase decision-making process – urging the receiver of the advertisement message to act in a certain way – interests us most in the present paper because it points both to the sender's intention and to the expected reaction of the receiver.

2. Analysis and classification of directions in written advertisements

2.1 The corpus

The corpus on which the analysis is performed comprises eighty-four written advertisements selected from the magazines and newspapers listed at the end of the present paper. The advertisements promote products (alcoholic and non-alcoholic drinks, beauty accessories, cars, cigarettes, clothes, computers, cosmetics, decorations, food and sweets, gas fires, home appliances, household necessities, medicines, post boxes, real estate), services (amusement activities, bathroom specialists, broadband and telephone services, contests, insurance services, pet adoption, travel offers, services offered by banks), and general interest issues (milk consumption and non-smoking).

2.2 Classification and analysis of directions

John Searle considers that "speaking a language is performing speech acts" (1994: 16), which are "the basic or minimal units of linguistic communication" (Searle, 1994:16). A speech act may be performed directly, i.e. one illocutionary act is performed directly by an utterance, or indirectly, i.e. "one illocutionary act is performed indirectly by way of performing another" (Searle, 1979: 31). He also identifies five classes of speech acts taking into account their illocutionary force, which is defined as a specific kind of action performed in speaking. The classes of illocutionary speech acts proposed by Searle are:

a. *Assertives / Representatives* commit the speaker to the truth of the expressed proposition, e.g. stating, claiming, reporting, concluding, confessing, confirming, etc.

b. *Directives* are attempts made by the speaker to get the hearer to do a volitional act, e.g. ordering, commanding, begging, challenging, requesting, questioning, advising, recommending, etc.

c. *Commissives* commit the speaker to some action, e.g. promising, offering, swearing, vowing, threatening, etc.

d. *Expressives* express the speaker's psychological state with respect to the state-of-affairs expressed by the propositional content, e.g. thanking, apologizing, blaming, pardoning, congratulating, condoling, welcoming, etc.

e. *Declaratives* bring about changes in the reality expressed by the propositional content, e.g. christening, resigning, dismissing, naming, appointing, sentencing, etc (Searle, 1976:1-24).

To put it differently, directive speech acts are actually requests for an action or information, i.e. they give the receiver directions aimed at determining him / her to act in a certain way.

While analyzing the eighty-four written advertisements of our corpus, we noticed that there are four types of directions that are given to the receiver of the advertisements:

- *imperative directions*, which direct the addressee how to use the product / service / issue;
- *interrogative directions*, which, in Searlean terms, are 'requests for information' (Searle, 1979: 147-148)
- *appellative directions*, which urge the addressee to consume or to find out more about the product;
- *indirect appellative directions*, which indirectly appeal to the addressee to consume or find out more about the product (they simply mention the website, telephone number, address, availability, validity, etc without integrating the information into a sentence).

Taking into consideration these four classes of directions used in the written advertisements building up our corpus, we focussed on their occurrence in written advertisements. The table and figure below show the results of our analysis.

Table 1. The use of directions in written advertisements

Directions in written advertisements	Number of advertisements in which a particular direction appears	Total number of written advertisements
Imperative direction	43	84
Interrogative direction	17	
Appellative direction	52	
Indirect a ppellative direction	39	

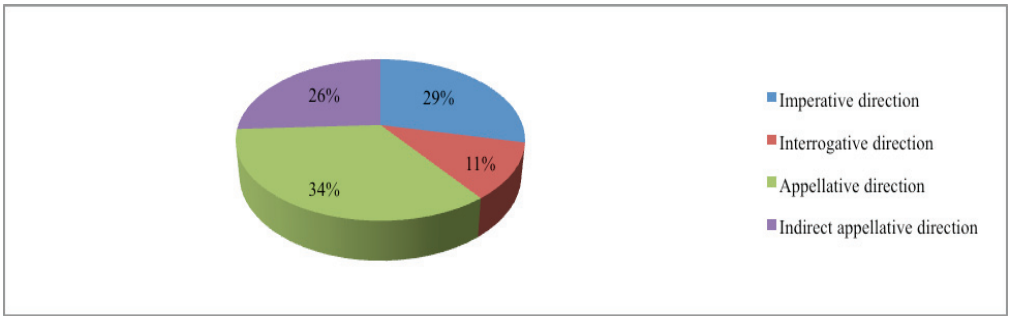


Fig. 1. The use of directions in written advertisements

2.3. Interpreting the results of the analysis

Our analysis of eighty-four written advertisements proves that 34% of the directions used in written advertisements are appellative, 29% are imperative, 26% are indirect appellative and 11% are interrogative. This shows that the advertisers prefer first to urge the audience directly to consume or find out more about the advertised product / service / issue. Second, the senders also instruct the receivers how to use the product / service / issue in order to get the best benefits. Third, indirect appeals are made to the receivers to consume or find out more about the product. These indirect appeals simply mention the website, telephone number, address, availability, validity, etc and do not integrate the information into a sentence. At last, the interrogative directions, which directly question the receiver whether s/he is interested in finding more information about the product / service / issue, are used.

3. Conclusion

The present paper has presented the economic conditions that made advertising an indispensable tool for increasing the demand for a certain product / service, or for influencing our beliefs about a certain issue. In order to attain their goal, the advertisers have to pay attention to certain communication objectives or stages in the purchase decision-making process. In the present paper we have focused on one of these stages, namely that in which the senders try to determine the receivers to act. In order to better understand the strategies underlying the advertisement message in this last stage, we have analysed the directions used in eighty-four written advertisements. For a more detailed analysis, we have proposed an enlargement of the class of speech acts called directions or directives, as Searle labelled them. The results of our analysis point to the advertisers' preference to directly urge the audience to consume or find information on the advertised product / issue / service, on the one hand and on the other to give them directions in terms of how to get the best benefits from the product / issue / service. 26% of the analysed advertisements simply mention the website, telephone number, address, availability, validity, etc, without including these details in a sentence that observes the linguistic sentence-building rules. The use of direct questions in which the receiver is asked about his / her interest in the offer is quite infrequent (11% of the analysed advertisements).

In other words, the direct appeals to consumption, the directions for use, the contact details and the details that

press the receiver to act in a limited period of time (checking availability or validity of an offer) are the most employed linguistic strategies of the advertisers, who, in this way, try to influence the consumers' choices. A surprising result is the fact that the senders rarely try to attract the receivers by checking their interest in the offer. Such a strategy could raise the receivers' awareness of the need satisfied by the offer and indirectly induce the feeling that the advertised product / service / issue is able to fill a gap in their lives.

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